

6 Lists

The fact is that the list is a very simple yet essential tool for organizing data, it is incredibly useful for the web designer. View the source code of any web site built using web standards, and you are almost guaranteed to see a list for the navigation buttons, a list for the external links, and probably a list for any buttons or arrays of data. Utilizing a list at an early stage of a web site project ensures the design will remain flexible and functional in any viewing scenario.

In this chapter, you'll be quickly reminded of the basic list markup and assess the different kind of lists that HTML provides, particularly unordered and ordered lists. We will learn to apply ID and classes to lists to attain greater control and then take things a bit further with nested lists controlled first with IDs and classes, and then manipulated with no extra markup, taking their basic hierarchies as hooks for more complex CSS control.

A list of items can be created in numerous ways in HTML, although all may not be semantically correct. The bad methods include adding a `<br />` tag after each item, or treating each item as a paragraph. The correct approach is to use an ordered or unordered list element, using the simple `<li>` tags for each item. The major benefit of this approach is that your list will be displayed as a numbered or bulleted list without the use of CSS, and is considerably easier to control with CSS. Using semantically correct list markup also makes it easy to single out items within a list, and also makes nested lists easier to manage.

6.1 Unordered list

Let us create a new template called `lists.html` and add the following markup inside the empty body element. Notice that the unordered list is placed inside a container, which will act as a hook for more CSS later in this section.

```
<div id="container">
<ul>
<li>Drinks Menu</li>
<li>Beer</li>
<li>Spirits</li>
<li>Cola</li>
<li>Lemonade</li>
<li>Tea</li>
```